

The God of Mt. Sinai Exodus 19:9ff

Introduction:

How familiar is God to you—how comfortable are you with God?

Today, we don't like to think much about such terms as "wrath" judgment, fire and brimstone... words that often are associated with pre-modern and pre-scientific and pre-sophistication...

These are, however, words that describe what happens when unholy people encounter a holy God...

Exposition:

Two weeks ago:

Exodus 19:1-8

"The covenant with Israel at Sinai is to bring Israel into a position of mediatorial service." (Eugene H. Merrill, "The Mosaic Covenant: A Proposal for Its Theological Significance," *Exegesis and Exposition* 3:1 (Fall 1988):29.)

"In contrast to the other covenants, the Mosaic covenant, though it had provisions for grace and forgiveness, nevertheless builds on the idea that obedience to God is necessary for blessing. While this to some extent is true in every dispensation, the Mosaic covenant was basically a works covenant rather than a grace covenant. The works principle, however, was limited to the matter of blessing in this life and was not related at all to the question of salvation for eternity."

(John F. Walvoord, "The New Covenant," in *Integrity of Heart, Skillfulness of Hands*, pp. 191-92.)

The works principle is exposed as fundamental to the propitiatory aspects of relating to God, even as was initiated in the garden with Adam and Eve...

E.g.

In response then to the conditional, works-based promise in 19:5-7

8 *The people all answered as one: "Everything that the LORD has spoken we will do*

Clearly, they overestimated their own ability to keep the covenant, and they underestimated God's standards for them. This twin error is traceable to a failure to appreciate their own sinfulness and God's holiness. The conditional aspect of *The Mosaic Law would teach them to appreciate both.*

There is therefore the need for God to satisfy the works of the covenant, and to make pure those who are soiled by their disobedience...

This begins to happen from the very outset of the context in which the law would be given as here described in our passage!

For Moses now goes back up the mountain and brings Israel's answer to the Lord (vs. 8b)—the second conversation and the circumstances that surround this, are recorded in vs. 9-13, followed by Moses going back to the people and executing the things that God prescribed by way of preparing them for the giving of God's law.

Text: 19:9-25

9 Then the LORD said to Moses, "I am going to come to you in a dense cloud, in order that the people may hear when I speak with you and so trust you ever after."

When Moses had told the words of the people to the LORD, 10 the LORD said to Moses: "Go to the people and consecrate them today and tomorrow. Have them wash their clothes 11 and prepare for the third day, because on the third day the LORD will come down upon Mount Sinai in the sight of all the people. 12 You shall set limits for the people all around, saying, 'Be careful not to go up the mountain or to touch the edge of it. Any who touch the mountain shall be put to death. 13 No hand shall touch them, but they shall be stoned or shot with arrows; whether animal or human being, they shall not live.' When the trumpet sounds a long blast, they may go up on the mountain." 14 So Moses went down from the mountain to the people. He consecrated the people, and they washed their clothes. 15 And he said to the people, "Prepare for the third day; do not go near a woman."

Ex. 19:16

On the morning of the third day there was thunder and lightning, as well as a thick cloud on the mountain, and a blast of a trumpet so loud that all the people who were in the camp trembled. 17 Moses brought the people out of the camp to meet God. They took their stand at the foot of the mountain. 18 Now Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke, because the LORD had descended upon it in fire; the smoke went up like the smoke of a kiln, while the whole mountain shook violently. 19 As the blast of the trumpet grew louder and louder, Moses would speak and God would answer him in thunder. 20 When the LORD descended upon Mount Sinai, to the top of the mountain, the LORD summoned Moses to the top of the mountain, and Moses went up. 21 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Go down and warn the people not to break through to the LORD to look; otherwise many of them will perish. 22 Even the priests who approach the LORD must consecrate themselves or the LORD will break out against them." 23 Moses said to the LORD, "The people are not permitted to come up to Mount Sinai; for you yourself warned us, saying, 'Set limits around the mountain and keep it holy.'" 24 The LORD said to him, "Go down, and come up bringing Aaron with you; but do not let either the priests or the people break through to come up to the LORD; otherwise he will break out against them." 25 So Moses went down to the people and told them.

Observations:

1. God speaks to Moses directly out of the cloud—an image we have seen before (13:21-22, 14:19-20-, 24, 16:10) even as we will see it again at the climax of the covenant stipulations 24:15ff, and at the end of Exodus in 40:34ff.

9 Then the LORD said to Moses, "I am going to come to you in a dense cloud, in order that the people may hear when I speak with you and so trust you ever after."

Ex. 13:22

Neither the pillar of cloud by day nor the pillar of fire by night left its place in front of the people.

Ex. 14:19

The angel of God who was going before the Israelite army moved and went behind them; and the pillar of cloud moved from in front of them and took its place behind them. 20 It came between the army of Egypt and the army of Israel. And so the cloud was there with the darkness, and it lit up the night; one did not come near the other all night.

"It is a sign of God's presence! An awe-inspiring frightening presences" (Durham) as we will see...

The "glory cloud was present at the tabernacle (or dwelling place) of God such that the glory cloud establishes the fact that Mt. Sinai was here and now "the dwelling place of God."

Ex. 33:9

When Moses entered the tent, the pillar of cloud would descend and stand at the entrance of the tent, and the LORD would speak with Moses. **10** When all the people saw the pillar of cloud standing at the entrance of the tent, all the people would rise and bow down, all of them, at the entrance of their tent.

Therefore, this first observation makes the point that Mt. Sinai is now the tabernacle of God as set apart by God's presence in the cloud!

The Presence of God that hemmed them in from in front and behind!

- ✓ The pillar of cloud is reminiscent of the Holy Spirit hovering over creation to bring salvation into chaos. The "Glory-Spirit"
- ✓ The fire is reminiscent of the theophany of God that appeared in the burning bush as again a manifestation of God's presence (Ex. 3—burning bush...)

Ex. 14:24

At the morning watch the LORD in the pillar of **fire** and cloud looked down upon the Egyptian army, and threw the Egyptian army into panic.

The pillar of cloud (Holy Spirit) and the fire (theophany) will climax at Mt. Sinai where that very presence of God that saved Israel is again active to establish Israel as a new Nation under new laws!

Here again, the story of Exodus is told with a particular emphasis upon the presence of God as the crucial issue... it is a story of God's presence, and how that presence changes everything! It is a revealing presence, a fighting presence, a guiding presence, a saving presence...

Exodus is the story of presence, even as this presence theology dominates the whole of redemptive history as ultimate accomplished in the presence of God via the Christ, even as the Christ has promised to be "present" in the context of the NC assembly no less so than in the OC assembly as defined and mediated through the visible church.

2. 10-13—instructions on how to meet God!

10 the LORD said to Moses: "Go to the people and consecrate them today and tomorrow. Have them wash their clothes **11** and prepare for the third day, because on the third day the LORD will come down upon Mount Sinai in the sight of all the people. **12** You shall set limits for the people all around, saying, 'Be careful not to go up the mountain or to touch the edge of it. Any who touch the mountain shall be put to death. **13** No hand shall touch them, but they shall be stoned or shot with arrows; whether animal or human being, they shall not live.' When the trumpet sounds a long blast, they may go up on the mountain."

- ✓ Washing cloths—in some ways analogous to Moses removing his shoes in Gods' presence in 3:5... But clearly this request anticipates a more explicitly spelled out cremonial duty related to ceremonial washings which directed Israel to both the holiness of God, the need for a "cleansing" as this was under the OC accomplished via the sacrificial system ultimately.

E.g. (see Lev.11-17, Num.19:7-21, 31:34)

Num. 8:7

Thus you shall do to them, to cleanse them: sprinkle the water of purification on them, have them shave their whole body with a razor and wash their clothes, and so cleanse themselves.

Num. 8:21

The Levites purified themselves from sin and washed their clothes; then Aaron presented them as an elevation offering before the LORD, and Aaron made atonement for them to cleanse them.

- ✓ Instructions about where to go/not to go relative to the mountain

Interestingly again, meeting God DID NOT mean marching up to the top of the mountain as Moses does... to go up they must wait for the blast of the ram's horn (vs. 13) and even then, the mountain is divided into three sections—not surprisingly corresponding to the three structural sections of the temple, which will dominate most of the second half of the book of Exodus.

E.g.

Top of the mountain—to which only Moses could access—corresponds to the Most Holy of Holies that only the high priest could enter 1 x/yr.

Middle section of the mountain—the seventy elders and priests are allowed—corresponding to the Holy Place in the temple... interestingly, this is the first reference to the Israelite priests in the OT... again demonstrating the evolving nature of this institution, as here foreshadowing the full orb institution under the Mosaic law...

The lower section of the mountain—where the rest of the people could go—corresponding to the outer court where the laity gather in the temple.

- ✓ Sexual restrictions vs. 15—at least on the surface—it seems that this was added by Moses, at least we don't have a record of these restrictions in the record of God's speaking to Moses... the command is unique even to the OC law—and hard to explain...

Constable:

The temporary prohibition against normal sexual relations (v. 15) seems intended to impress the importance of this occasion on the Israelites and to help them concentrate on it. We should not infer from this command that normal sexual relations are sinful (cf. Gen. 1:28; 9:1, 7). Abstention was for ritual cleanness, not moral cleanness.

And finally, and perhaps most importantly as the climax to our passage:

3. Descriptions of the curses that will come upon the people if they violate the instruction for how to approach God... "death"

12: Be careful not to go up the mountain or to touch the edge of it. Any who touch the mountain shall be put to death.

21 Then the LORD said to Moses, "Go down and warn the people not to break through to the LORD to look; otherwise many of them will perish.

24 Go down, and come up bringing Aaron with you; but do not let either the priests or the people break through to come up to the LORD; otherwise he will break out against them."

I.e. the passage is clearly dominated by this theme, as the same warning is repeated 3 times! (12-13, 21-22, 24)

- Premature advance whether by man or animal will result in death by stoning or being shot by arrows, lest even the perpetrators themselves be touched by those carrying out the sentence

In sum: The topic of this passage is clearly centered on the topic of meeting with God! And clearly it was a serious matter to approach God in a wrong way... such that the penalty for misconduct in approaching God was death—repeated three times!

Not we should think about this for a moment!

Durham: "It is striking that these people whom God loves and has compassion on, are guided to this holy place to meet their God and yet upon their arrival are kept at arm's length... the fact that limits are placed around the mountain accents the holiness of God's dwelling... "

And yet, however fascinated, even perplexed we might be at the seriousness—what is perhaps most perplexing is that the author of this passage shows no sign of perplexity! Whatever is true about God, and whatever is true about the people, is such as to make the seriousness of meeting with God, coupled with the ultimate curse for doing so wrongly, seem completely natural and right!

What do we know about God, both as revealed here and elsewhere, that would make sense of this?

Well—to say it plainly—we know that *God is a consuming fire*—whatever else he is along with this... as then clearly depicting his absolute holiness as to require absolute purity to be in his presence!

Look again at how God is revealed in this episode:

*there was thunder and lightning, as well as a thick cloud on the mountain, and a blast of a trumpet... **18** Now Mount Sinai was wrapped in smoke, because the LORD had **descended upon it in fire**; the smoke went up like the smoke of a kiln, while the whole mountain shook violently. **19** As the blast of the trumpet grew louder and louder*

AS this passage is summarized in the NT Hebrews:

Heb. 12:29 for indeed our God is a consuming *fire*.

Keeping in mind that the Mt. Is now a "tabernacle" as established by God's glory presence in the cloud... there is a necessary acknowledgment that God is by nature holy even as the people are not... his holiness by nature is such as to necessarily refine unholiness as through fire... therefore... The images of fire is here manifest as pertaining to the necessary judgment of God against all sin...

fire—a common event in the advent of God... God's advent in the OT is often identified with fire:

Ex. 13:21

The LORD went in front of them in a pillar of cloud by day, to lead them along the way, and in a pillar of fire by night, to give them light, so that they might travel by day and by night. 22 Neither the pillar of cloud by day nor the pillar of fire by night left its place in front of the people.

Exodus 3:1-6-- like a burning fire

Throughout the OT and New, Fire depicts the cleansing that comes by burning—as to purity or burn away all impurities—it is also associated then with judgment... such that throughout the OC system—holiness and fire are associated... eg.g. Fire is a symbol of His holiness that enlightens, purges, and refines. The smoke and quaking that accompanied the fire further impressed this awesome revelation on the people.

Num. 31:23

everything that can withstand fire, shall be passed through fire, and it shall be clean. Nevertheless it shall also be purified with the water for purification; and whatever cannot withstand fire, shall be passed through the water.

Lev. 2:10

And what is left of the grain offering shall be for Aaron and his sons; it is a most holy part of the offerings by fire to the LORD.

Lev. 6:17

It shall not be baked with leaven. I have given it as their portion of my offerings by fire; it is most holy, like the sin offering and the guilt offering. 18 Every male among the descendants of Aaron shall eat of it, as their perpetual due throughout your generations, from the LORD'S offerings by fire; anything that touches them shall become holy.

Lev. 6:30

But no sin offering shall be eaten from which any blood is brought into the tent of meeting for atonement in the holy place; it shall be burned with fire.

Lev. 10:12

Moses spoke to Aaron and to his remaining sons, Eleazar and Ithamar: Take the grain offering that is left from the LORD'S offerings by fire, and eat it unleavened beside the altar, for it is most holy; 13 you shall eat it in a holy place, because it is your due and your sons' due, from the offerings by fire to the LORD; for so I am commanded.

Lev. 16:27

The bull of the sin offering and the goat of the sin offering, whose blood was brought in to make atonement in the holy place, shall be taken outside the camp; their skin and their flesh and their dung shall be consumed in fire.

✓ **Lev. 21:6**

They shall be holy to their God, and not profane the name of their God; for they offer the LORD'S offerings by fire, the food of their God; therefore they shall be holy.

Lev. 23:8

For seven days you shall present the LORD'S offerings by fire; on the seventh day there shall be a holy convocation: you shall not work at your occupations.

Ezek. 28:14

With an anointed cherub as guardian I placed you;
you were on the holy mountain of God;

you walked among the stones of fire.

Is. 6:3

And one called to another and said:

"Holy, holy, holy is the LORD of hosts;
the whole earth is full of his glory."

Illus... So purely cold is dry ice—that it will burn the skin when touched...

Purified as by fire...

Main Point: Our God is a Holy God, which then means that he is a consuming fire when met with unholiness! It is a dangerous and serious thing to encounter God...

Therefore, the Israelites are in need of "cleansing"-- before approaching God at his holy mountain.

10 the LORD said to Moses: "Go to the people and consecrate them today and tomorrow

Consecrate—the verb form derived from the same root as the adjective form "holy"

God designed the procedures He specified to help the people realize the difference between their holy God and their sinful selves. Notice that God separated Himself from the Israelites spatially and temporally.

Calvin:

because it is expedient that the proud and improperly arrogant should be kept within His narrow limit, that they may be reminded of their weakness. To alarm them yet more, He commands that the men themselves, and even beasts, though harmless, should be killed if they passed over the borders... that this terrible spectacle was partly to set the presence of God before their eyes, that His majesty might urge the beholders to obedience, and vindicate His doctrine (concerning himself?) from contempt, and partly to express the nature of the Law, which in itself produces nothing but mere terror.

Our passage sets up the whole of the OC law—even as the law reveals something very important about how we are to related to God...

The "tension" is intentional..

E.g.

A God who longs to meet with and be in the midst of his people for the sake of his glory and their benefit, but a God who is holy and is to remain holy all the same..

Our passage perfectly sets this tension up as it will be worked out in the OC law—a law that perfectly foreshadows the way this tension is to be ultimately resolved by Christ in the NC.

New Covenant teaching:

What is the Gospel as exposed by our passage today?

Whatever else it is, the gospel

Doesn't involve the reduction of God... But the expansion of God's grace!

So then, a passage that directly makes use of our Exodus passage is Heb. 12:18ff...

Same God:

Heb. 12:18

You have not come to something that can be touched, a blazing fire, and darkness, and gloom, and a tempest, **19** and the sound of a trumpet, and a voice whose words made the hearers beg that not another word be spoken to them. **20** (For they could not endure the order that was given, "If even an animal touches the mountain, it shall be stoned to death." **21** **Indeed, so terrifying was the sight that Moses said, "I tremble with fear."**)

E.g. the God of the NT is the same God of the OT— a God that cannot be touched
Trans—God is holy other—God is not to be messed with, meeting God is the most aw-ful event one could ever have!

Same God

29 *for indeed our God is a consuming fire.*

Same Warning Concerning God's word: that we take heed to what is said... we are to be judged by it!

Heb. 12:25

See that you do not refuse the one who is speaking; for if they did not escape when they refused the one who warned them on earth, how much less will we escape if we reject the one who warns from heaven! **26** At that time his voice shook the earth; but now he has promised, "Yet once more I will shake not only the earth but also the heaven." **27** This phrase, "Yet once more," indicates the removal of what is shaken—that is, created things—so that what cannot be shaken may remain.

We must take God seriously by recognizing our need for

Different means of approaching God in order not to be destroyed!

Not by washings, but by Christ...

22 But you have come to Mount Zion and to the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and to innumerable angels in festal gathering, **23** and to the assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven, and to God the judge of all, and to the **spirits of the righteous made perfect**, **24** and to Jesus, **the mediator of a new covenant**, and to the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel.

Different motivation

28 Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us give thanks,

Same goal

by which we offer to God an acceptable worship with reverence and awe;

Explain:

❖ **NO reduction in God—God IS a consuming fire**

God has not changed! He is the same God under the NT as under the OT! Nor is Jesus less than God himself!

God is a consuming fire, Jesus no less is a consuming fire! (See Rev. 1 below)

God is as much a terrifying and awe-inspiring and fearful being to be reckoned with today as ever! The NC scripture are filled with illustrations and stories concerning the holiness of God as a reality that can not be underestimated, as is the habit of many these days.

Illus:

Matt. 7:19

Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the **fire**.

Matt. 13:40

Just as the weeds are collected and burned up with **fire**, so will it be at the end of the age.

Matt. 13:42

and they will throw them into the furnace of **fire**, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

Matt. 13:50

and throw them into the furnace of **fire**, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.

Luke 3:9

Even now the ax is lying at the root of the trees; every tree therefore that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the **fire**."

Luke 3:16

John answered all of them by saying, "I baptize you with water; but one who is more powerful than I is coming; I am not worthy to untie the thong of his sandals. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and **fire**. **17** His winnowing fork is in his hand, to clear his threshing floor and to gather the wheat into his granary; but the chaff he will burn with unquenchable **fire**."

Again, God has not changed! Nor is Jesus less than God himself!

God is a consuming fire, Jesus no less is a consuming fire!

As a consuming fire, we are reminded of what happens when unholy people encounter a holy God... lest we grow too familiar with God, lest we grow too complacent in the prospect of meeting up with him, lest those who are in Christ grow numb to the immeasurable gift of God's grace that we have been invited to his presence without fear of being consumed!

Review of what we believe:

That God is a consuming fire

Heidelberg Confession

Question 10. Will God suffer such disobedience and rebellion to go unpunished?

Answer: By no means; but is terribly displeased (a) with our original as well as actual sins; and will punish them in his just judgment temporally and eternally, (b) as he has declared, "Cursed is every one that continueth not in all things, which are written in the book of the law, to do them." (c)

(a) Gen.2:17 But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it: for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die. Rom.5:12 Wherefore, as by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned: (b) Ps.5:5 The foolish shall not stand in thy sight: thou hatest all workers of iniquity. Ps.50:21 These things hast thou done, and I kept silence; thou thoughtest that I was altogether such an one as thyself: but I will reprove thee, and set them in order before thine eyes. Nah.1:2 God is jealous, and the LORD revengeth; the LORD revengeth, and is furious; the LORD will take vengeance on his adversaries, and he reserveth wrath for his enemies. Exod.20:5 Thou shalt not bow down thyself to them, nor serve them: for I the LORD thy God am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation of them that hate me; Exod.34:7 Keeping mercy for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, and that will by no means clear the guilty; visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children, and upon the children's children, unto the third and to the fourth generation. Rom.1:18 For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who hold the truth in unrighteousness; Eph.5:6 Let no man deceive you with vain words: for because of these things cometh the wrath of God upon the children of disobedience. Heb.9:27 And as it is appointed unto men once to die, but after this the judgment: (c) Deut.27:26 Cursed be he that confirmeth not all the words of this law to do them. And all the people shall say, Amen. Gal.3:10 For as many as are of the works of the law are under the curse: for it is written, Cursed is every one that continueth not in all things which are written in the book of the law to do them.

❖ Expansion in God's grace

Under the NC—while God is the same God today, yesterday and forever, the revelation of God's grace is expanded as revealed in Christ.

The Consecrating procedures foreshadow the consecration accomplished on our behalf by Christ!
Therefore,

Question 11. Is not God then also merciful?

Answer: God is indeed merciful, (a) but also just; (b) therefore his justice requires, that sin which is committed against the most high majesty of God, be also punished with extreme, that is, with everlasting punishment of body and soul.

(a) Exod.34:6 And the LORD passed by before him, and proclaimed, The LORD, The LORD God, merciful and gracious, longsuffering, and abundant in goodness and truth, Exod.34:7 Keeping mercy for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, and that will by no means clear the guilty; visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children, and upon the children's children, unto the third and to the fourth generation. Exod.20:6 And shewing mercy unto thousands of them that love me, and keep my commandments. (b) Ps.7:9 Oh let the wickedness of the wicked come to an end; but establish the just: for the righteous God trieth the hearts and reins. Exod.20:5 Thou shalt not bow down thyself to them, nor serve them: for I the LORD thy God am a jealous God, visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children unto the third and fourth generation of them that hate me; Exod.23:7 Keep thee far from a false matter; and the innocent and righteous slay thou not: for I will not justify the wicked. Exod.34:7 Keeping mercy for thousands, forgiving iniquity and transgression and sin, and that will by no means clear the guilty; visiting the iniquity of the fathers upon the children, and upon the children's children, unto the third and to the fourth generation. Ps.5:5 The foolish shall not stand in thy sight: thou hatest all workers of iniquity. Ps.5:6 Thou shalt destroy them that speak leasing: the LORD will abhor the bloody and deceitful man. Nah.1:2 God is jealous,

and the LORD revengeth; the LORD revengeth, and is furious; the LORD will take vengeance on his adversaries, and he reserveth wrath for his enemies. Nah.1:3 The LORD is slow to anger, and great in power, and will not at all acquit the wicked: the LORD hath his way in the whirlwind and in the storm, and the clouds are the dust of his feet.

What we could, not do, what all the washings and ceremonies themselves could not do, God could, in showing mercy to us by making us holy in standing such as to not be consumed by a holy God!

Rom.8:3 For what the law could not do, in that it was weak through the flesh, God sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh, and for sin, condemned sin in the flesh: **4** That the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.

E.g. God's grace is revealed in an every expanding way and ultimately perfected in the work of Jesus Christ...

Question 19. From the holy gospel, which God himself first revealed in Paradise; (a) and afterwards published by the patriarchs (b) and prophets, (c) and represented by the sacrifices and other ceremonies of the law; (d) and lastly, has fulfilled it by his only begotten Son. (e)

Acts 10:43 To him give all the prophets witness, that through his name whosoever believeth in him shall receive remission of sins. John 5:46 For had ye believed Moses, ye would have believed me: for he wrote of me. (d) Heb.10:1 For the law having a shadow of good things to come, and not the very image of the things, can never with those sacrifices which they offered year by year continually make the comers thereunto perfect. Heb.10:7 Then said I, Lo, I come (in the volume of the book it is written of me,) to do thy will, O God. Col.2:7 Rooted and built up in him, and stablished in the faith, as ye have been taught, abounding therein with thanksgiving. John 5:46 For had ye believed Moses, ye would have believed me: for he wrote of me. (e) Rom.10:4 For Christ is the end of the law for righteousness to every one that believeth. Gal.4:4 But when the fulness of the time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law, Gal.4:5 To redeem them that were under the law, that we might receive the adoption of sons. Gal.3:24 Wherefore the law was our schoolmaster to bring us unto Christ, that we might be justified by faith. Col.2:17 Which are a shadow of things to come; but the body is of Christ.

Faith in Christ, in so far as it embraces the offer of reconciliation and the Spirit of regeneration, can alone truly purify us...

There is therefore still a need to be "cleansed" before we can meet God!

Under the OC—this was accomplished ceremonially—but not really—even as the ceremony anticipated the real cleansing that would be accomplished by the ultimate priest...

Heb. 10:1

For the Law, since it has only a shadow of the good things to come and not the very form of things, can never by the same sacrifices year by year, which they offer continually, make perfect those who draw near.

E.g. the lesser shadows have given way to the greater realities—even as the Israelites were cleansed by faith in a ceremonial system of cleansing rites, washings and consecrating rituals, their faith if real was ultimately in a promised exposed by these rites that are ultimately accomplished by the cleansing blood of Christ.

Application:

1. Do you know your God such as to “fear” him?

Is your God too familiar?

Think about this for a minute:

Abraham so “feared” God that he was willing to sacrifice his own son to satisfy God...

Gen. 22:12

He said, “Do not lay your hand on the boy or do anything to him; for now I know that you **fear** God, since you have not withheld your son, your only son, from me.”

Joseph

Gen. 42:18

On the third day Joseph said to them, “Do this and you will live, for I **fear** God:

Night of Passover

Ex. 15:16

Terror and **dread** fell upon them;
by the might of your arm, they became still as a stone
until your people, O LORD, passed by,
until the people whom you acquired passed by.

Thus we are properly exhorted...

Psa. 33:8

Let all the earth **fear** the LORD;
let all the inhabitants of the world stand in awe of him.

Seeker—you may at first find this sermon sound like ‘bad news’—and indeed, without Christ it would be! E.g. a passage that reveals God in his holiness in contrast to our unholiness is a serious passage indeed..

You might well be thinking—I want NOTHING to do with this kind of religion and this kind of God... (explain)

But consider for a moment would you—what are the alternatives

Our passage says this basically—that death and suffering is a due to humanities attempt to “meet God” unprepared—e.g. as reiterated in Gen 3 (fall), to Gen. 5 (Cain), to Gen. 11 (Babel) to.... even Annanias and Saphira (Acts 3)... our problems are due to our attempt to meet God wrongly, as to even remake God in our own image or to satisfy God by our own accomplishments- which all said and done FAILED to consecrate (sanctify) us in order to meet God.

Our problem is that we are under a curse!!! Such that the solution is only in that which can take the curse away by properly sanctifying us and presenting us to God as holy!

What the alternative to this take on the world?
Sentimental humanism???

are you not growing tired of all this humanism? Do we not grow weary of all this "*I can do anything you can do better, I can do anything better than you...*"?

The Humanism of the 70's- 90's is not only boring—it is down right sentimental... we all know it really—

Illus. John Stoessinger's "Why Nation's God to War"
I found myself both attracted to and repulsed by his thesis... which is basically this

On the one hand, he is weary of all the systemic analysis and "excuses" for war... "the conventional wisdom that wars were caused by nationalism, militarism, alliance systems, economic factors or some other "fundamental causes" he said, "left (him) totally dissatisfied both intellectually and emotionally.

As a Christian, I agree, in that Stroessinger further states his case for what he calls the "personality dimensions"

"The outline for this book grew out of my need to know the human truth behind the mechanistic forces..."

Okay, I said, right on—e.g rather than impersonal forces—lets talk about the personal forces...

And so, using the case study is of the two world wars, Korea, Vietnam, India and Pakistan, the Arab States and Israel, Saddam Hussein's two wars in the Persian Gulf and Yugoslavia.. he focused on the so called moments of truth when leaders crossed the threshold into war...

His analysis (at least what I have read so far) is indeed compelling—as to show the bad decisions, the arrogance, the greed, the naiveté, on and on—of human leaders that led us to war...

Okay—I say—so what is the conclusion we should take from all of this?

His conclusion is basically—we can do better—by learning from past mistakes, we can avoid war.

"Perhaps chaos is a name we give to an order that as yet we do not understand. I hope that this book may bring some order to the chaos by presenting some original perspective.. and such insight, I dare hope, may be the first step to liberation"

UGGGG--- the same ole sentimentalism— "*I can do anything you can do better, I can do anything better than you...*"

See also Roger Eghert's review of the movie: "THE FOG OF WAR" and especially his reference to Robert McNamara's "11 Lessons From the Life of Robert McNamara," Lessons include No. 1 and 2 ("Empathize with your enemy" and "Rationality will not save us"), or for that matter No. 6 ("Get the data"), No. 7 ("Belief and seeing are both often wrong") and No. 8 ("Be prepared to reexamine your reasoning").

Some commentators on the film, notably Kaplan in his informative Slate essay, question McNamara's facts. What cannot be questioned is his ability to question them himself. At 85, he knows what he knows, and what he does not know, and what cannot be known. Lesson No. 11: "You can't change human nature."

IF you are tired of the same ole same ole—humanism run amuck— if you are tired of a closed system analysis of everything such as to crown humanity as the end all of everything—if you are looking for an explanation of suffering and a solution to suffering that is, well, not of this world ultimately—

Then here is your passage!

Why do we have wars? Ultimate—wars are the curse upon humanity for its failure to "respect that there is a God, and that this God is holy, is a consuming fire!

It is curse for not being clean—for transgressing the holy mountain if you will, even as this whole of the world was created to be a holy habitation for God

The solution?

Here is it stated, plain and simple...

The problem in the world is that it lacks the knowledge of a holy and just God, and it lacks the means by which we are to be consecrated to him.. which then again begs for an other worldly, non-humanistic solution!

2. The Resulting urge to be cleansed: People who discover the true God, rightly want to be cleansed in order to be in his presence...

Calvin:

In the smoke and fire, and other signs, some fear was added, in accordance with the office of the Law, because the sinner will never be capable of pardon until he learns to tremble from consciousness of his guilt, nay, until confounded with dread he lies like one dead before the tribunal of God.

The right and wrong way to be consecrated

Wrong way:

1. People who discover God and realize their need of cleansing may wrongly try to wash themselves!

Many ways to do this:

- a) Penance—self-condemnation and self- punishment...

Many ways:

- By confession sins over and over again in a way that intentionally brings embarrassment, etc.
- By suffering intentionally...
- By not allowing oneself to have fun...
- Etc.

The scarlet letter— ScarletRed “A” on her chest,..

Don’t we even do this to each other- as if we can clean them by putting their sins out for everyone to see...

b) Phariseeism—self-righteousness—find a few things and give your whole life perfecting it... as if to be pure in a few things makes you pure in the whole law...
Of course, it was James that reminded believers that if we fail even one part of the law, we fail the whole...

Right way—believe Christ... “your sins are forgiven”

It was that easy—that quick, that complete, that final!

Luke 7:36

One of the Pharisees asked Jesus to eat with him, and he went into the Pharisee’s house and took his place at the table. **37 And a woman in the city, who was a sinner,** having learned that he was eating in the Pharisee’s house, brought an alabaster jar of ointment. **38** She stood behind him at his feet, **weeping**, and began to bathe his feet with her tears and to dry them with her hair. Then she continued kissing his feet and anointing them with the ointment. **39** Now when the Pharisee who had invited him saw it, he said to himself, “**If this man were a prophet, he would have known who and what kind of woman this is who is touching him—that she is a sinner.**” **40** Jesus spoke up and said to him, “Simon, I have something to say to you.” “Teacher,” he replied, “Speak.” **41** “A certain creditor had two debtors; one owed five hundred denarii, and the other fifty. **42** When they could not pay, he canceled the debts for both of them. Now which of them will love him more?” **43** Simon answered, “I suppose the one for whom he canceled the greater debt.” And Jesus said to him, “You have judged rightly.” **44** Then turning toward the woman, he said to Simon, “Do you see this woman? I entered your house; you gave me no water for my feet, but she has bathed my feet with her tears and dried them with her hair. **45** You gave me no kiss, but from the time I came in she has not stopped kissing my feet. **46** You did not anoint my head with oil, but she has anointed my feet with ointment. **47 Therefore, I tell you, her sins, which were many, have been forgiven; hence she has shown great love.** But the one to whom little is forgiven, loves little.” **48** Then he said to her, “Your sins are forgiven.” **49** But those who were at the table with him began to say among themselves, “Who is this who even forgives sins?” **50** And he said to the woman, “Your faith has saved you; go in peace.”

John 15:3

You have already been **cleansed** by the word that I have spoken to you.

1John 2:12

I am writing to you, little children,
because your **sins are forgiven** on account of his name.

Heb. 10:22

let us **approach** with a true heart in full assurance of faith, with our hearts sprinkled **clean** from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water.

Conclusion:

You will, as certain as I am standing here before you today—meet God—the same God as was encountered by the people of Israel at Mt. Sinai...

It may be in a year, 10 years, 30, at best 80 or so... but you will encounter the God we have encountered in our passage today.

So the question is this—will you be destroyed by this encounter or eternally blessed by it?

On the one hand, you can keep trying to do penance, or you can reduce God and his laws, and exalt yourself... OR you can by faith be made ready! And the whole burden of life under God's curse is lifted!

Which will it be...

As then you contemplate this—consider what we have here to do next and the one that we encounter by it...

Lord's Supper:

Another important passage that at the very least eludes to our passage is in Rev.

Revelations: The Ancient of Days

10 I was in the spirit on the Lord's day, and I heard behind me a loud voice like a trumpet

Rev. 1:12

*Then I turned to see whose voice it was that spoke to me, and on turning I saw seven golden lampstands, **13** and in the midst of the lampstands I saw one like the Son of Man, clothed with a long robe and with a golden sash across his chest. **14** His head and his hair were white as white wool, white as snow; his eyes were like a flame of fire, **15** his feet were like burnished bronze, refined as in a furnace, and his voice was like the sound of many waters. **16** In his right hand he held seven stars, and from his mouth came a sharp, two-edged sword, and his face was like the sun shining with full force.*

Dan. 7:9

"I kept looking Until thrones were set up, And the Ancient of Days took His seat; His vesture was like white snow, And the hair of His head like pure wool. His throne was ablaze with flames, Its wheels were a burning fire.

"as a great voice as a trumpet"-- evoking the voice that Moses heard when Yahweh revealed himself on Mt. Sinai (Ex.19:16, 19-20) ...

Ex. 19:16

¶ On the morning of the third day there was thunder and lightning, as well as a thick cloud on the mountain, and a *blast of a trumpet* so loud that all the people who were in the camp trembled.

Ex. 19:19

As the *blast of the trumpet* grew louder and louder, Moses would speak and God would answer him in thunder. **20** When the LORD descended upon Mount Sinai, to the top of the mountain, the LORD summoned Moses to the top of the mountain, and Moses went u

You can almost feel John's loss of breath at the glimpse of "*one like the son of man*"
in the middle one like son of man...

Notice that the "son of man" replaces the image of the "Holy of Holies" in the OT temple

"and lo, I am with you..." then, God was with his people as mediated through the Holy of Holies-- then the H of H would have invoked such visions of God that would encourage them to persevere!

now, mediated through the NT means of grace in NT worship... but it's the vision of God as revealed in Jesus Christ that is here depicted!

And again, to understand the meaning of the details, we need to see the vision in the context of the OT!

These OT vision of the glorified God are clearly depicted in Christ as the divine one--

Mt.17:1-8-- --Transfiguration

Acts 9:3-6, 17, 20) Paul's vision on road to Damascus

We remember Jesus's self-proclamation about himself after the resurrection:

Mt.28:18-20-- that he now had all authority in heaven and earth!

Rev. 19:12

His eyes are like a flame of **fire**, and on his head are many diadems; and he has a name inscribed that no one knows but himself.

Rev. 19:20

And the beast was captured, and with it the false prophet who had performed in its presence the signs by which he deceived those who had received the mark of the beast and those who worshiped its image. These two were thrown alive into the lake of **fire** that burns with sulfur.

Rev. 20:9

They marched up over the breadth of the earth and surrounded the camp of the saints and the beloved city. And **fire** came down from heaven and consumed them. **10** And the devil who had deceived them was thrown into the lake of **fire** and sulfur, where the beast and the false prophet were, and they will be tormented day and night forever and ever.

Rev. 20:14

Then Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of **fire**. This is the second death, the lake of **fire**; **15** and anyone whose name was not found written in the book of life was thrown into the lake of **fire**.

Rev. 21:8

But as for the cowardly, the faithless, the polluted, the murderers, the fornicators, the sorcerers, the idolaters, and all liars, their place will be in the lake that burns with **fire** and sulfur, which is the second death."

But consider this—even as John was filled with dread at the sight of the glorified Christ, the same image that filled Moses with dread centuries earlier... Christ does something that if we really understood its significance would move us to unimaginably comforts...

Right would you would expect the fire to burn John (and us)... our text informs us that I fell at his feet as though dead. But *he placed his right hand on me, saying, "Do not be afraid"*

In effect—this table reminds us of these words—rather than keeping us at arms length, God invites us in—rather than being properly filled with the dread of it, we are comforted "do not be afraid"

The words speak volumes upon volumes as revealed by this meal..

How it is that we are consecrated for God by the blood and sacrifice of Christ

How it is that we ought rightly to expect God condemnation, but we gain God's approval instead

How it is that we should expect rejection, but we gain perfect and unconditional acceptance

How it is that our encounter at this table ought to be hostile, but it is instead the reunion of child to his/her beloved and most gracious father...

How it is that...